

The Long Way Home

The windswept shores of Troy stretch along a bright Aegean sea, where wooden ships with painted eyes lie beached on the long sand and a great city of honey-coloured walls stands proud on the hill above. For a long while two camps, the weary seafarers on the beach and the proud city behind its gates, have been caught in a tired old quarrel that neither truly wants. Across the wine-dark sea lies the long road home, full of wonders: a loyal old hound, a keeper of the winds, and lonely sea-singers on the rocks. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who is clever, brave, and keeps faith with a friend. The grandest deeds are done not with spears but with a good idea and a kind heart, and the oldest quarrels often end with a single brave act of friendship.



The Long Way Home

Read aloud, slowly and warmly. Stop often to let the children answer. There are no wrong answers here, only brave new ideas to try.

Before you begin

The long quarrel is over, and it ended not with spears but with friendship. The great gates of Troy stand open, and now it is time to sail home across the Wine-Dark Sea. Far away waits the Weaving Hall, where a warm fire, a homecoming feast, and old friends are ready for you.

Odysseus the Clever walks you down to the ships on the long sandy beach. "It is a long way home," he says, "and the sea is wide. But you are clever, you are brave, and you keep faith with your friends. That is all a sailor truly needs."

He gives you three gifts for the journey: a great spiral Conch Horn, a Basket of Honey and Figs, and a ball of strong thread, Penelope's Thread. Then he smiles. "Out there we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and loyal."

What is your hero name? Are you a hero of Cleverness, of Courage, or of Loyalty?

Stop 1: The Isle of Winds

You sail for many days until you come to a floating island ringed with shining bronze cliffs. This is the Isle of Winds, where Aeolus, Keeper of the Winds, lives. He keeps all the winds of the world tied up safe in a great leather bag.

Aeolus is kind, but he is careful. He will only lend a fair wind to travellers who ask cleverly and politely, and who are not greedy. "Ask me nicely," he says, "and never, ever peek inside the wind-bag."

How will you ask for a fair wind? Could you think of clever, kind words to say? Could you promise not to peek inside the bag? What do you try?

When you ask cleverly and kindly, Aeolus laughs and ties a gentle wind into your sail. "A fair wind for friends," he says, and waves you off across the water.

Stop 2: The Singing Sirens

For a long while you sail on. Then you hear it: a song floating over the sea, beautiful and so very sad. It comes from the Singing Sirens, sea-singers who sit on the lonely rocks. Their song is so lonely that ships drift off course just to follow it.

This is not a danger to run from. Listen closely. The Sirens are not wicked at all. They are only lonely, because nobody ever stays to be their friend.

This is not a fight, and it is not a race to escape. What kind thing could you do? You could sing a song back to them. You could sound the Conch Horn. You could share your Basket of Honey and Figs. What do you try?

When you answer their loneliness with kindness, the Sirens stop their sad song. They laugh, they wave, and they begin to sing a bright and happy tune that guides your ship safely past the rocks. "Come back and visit us!" they call.

Stop 3: Home at Last

At last, far ahead, you see a shore you know. Your heart beats fast. Is this really home? You must look closely and be sure.

You step onto the sand and find the path up to the Weaving Hall. There, through the door, you can see the great loom where a friend has been weaving while you were away. An old friend

looks up. And there, by the fire, an old dog lifts his grey head and sniffs the air.

How will you know you are truly home? What do you remember about this place? Look for the loom, for an old friend, for the faithful hound. Who waits by the fire?

It is Argos the Faithful Hound! He has never forgotten you. He trots up, his tail wagging so hard it nearly knocks him over, and you are home at last.

Home at Last

The Weaving Hall is warm and full of light. The homecoming feast is laid out: warm bread, sweet figs, and honey. Old friends hug you and call your hero name. Argos the Faithful Hound will not leave your side.

High above the calm water, Thetis the Sea-Mother smiles down on you. You crossed the whole Wine-Dark Sea and came home together. You were clever, you were brave, and most of all you kept faith with your friends. Well done, heroes. Welcome home.

The Story in Pictures



A gentle keeper of the winds on a floating bronze-cliffed island, handing two older heroes a soft leather bag holding a fair wind.



Two older heroes on a small ship near a rocky isle where gentle wistful sea-singers sing, the heroes sounding a conch and singing back kindly, the singers looking lonely rather than frightening.



Two older heroes arriving home at a warm hall across the sea, a great loom in the lamplight and a homecoming feast being laid, old friends rising to greet them.



A joyful homecoming feast in a warm hall, two older heroes reunited with friends and a faithful old hound, a gentle sea goddess smiling through a window of evening light.

My Adventure Sheet

Draw your hero

My name

I am a hero of

My energy stars (colour one in when you spend it)



My magics



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can



My magic is

It can

What I carry

Notes

Here nobody loses. If a try does not work, find another way.

Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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Version 2, updated 2026-06-04, en-GB



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